

MAKING DEBATE NORMAL: THE TEXAS NORMAL DEBATING LEAGUE'S DEMOCRATIC AND PEDOGOGICAL FUNCTIONS

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Abstract: Even before the founding of the National Association of Academic Teachers of Public Speaking, there were debate leagues that involved speech teachers from around the United States. William Keith (2007, 2008), Herman Cohen (1994), Pat Gehrke (2009) and others have noted the imbrication of the discipline of speech with the instruction of debate however, little has been done to assess the local character of debate education before the national organizations were formed. This paper pulls information from archival documentation, newspaper articles, magazine status updates, and articles inside the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking* to examine the state of debate in one such local collection of speech educators: the Texas Normal Debate League (TNDL). The TNDL formed in the early 1900s among teacher colleges in Texas, called Normal colleges at the time, and thus gives unique insight into not only the ways that debate evolved, but also the priorities of training speech educators at the time. This paper argues that the educative goal of debate as a form of civic engagement is deeply rooted in the TNDL and that attending to the history of Normal Leagues might offer some suggestions for debate practitioners in the contemporary era. The Normal Leagues provide a case where students were able to bridge policy and public deliberation in a way that emphasized civic education.

The connection between competitive debate and democracy continues to be a contested terrain (Bsumek, 2009; Keith, 2007; Lain, Hlavacik, Ivanovic, &

Ontiveros-Kersch, in press). As noted by Bsumek (2009) the “assumptions about the necessary relationship between debate, deliberation and democracy are not only foundational to western thought, they are also found in the disciplinary bedrock of communication studies” (p. 1). The tension between competitive debate and democracy continues to re-emerge. In 2014, a call for conference papers on “Speech & Debate as Civic Education” argued that debate programs have “lost sight of their connections to civic education” (“Speech & Debate,” n.d, para. 1). Keith (2007) tackled the challenge of viewing competitive debate as democratizing in his book *Democracy as Discussion*. Keith’s history of competitive debate summarized that “within a Progressivist notion of democracy, debate instruction emerged, fell short, and thus gave birth (with John Dewey’s help) to a new pedagogy, *discussion*, which explicitly embodied political ideals which debate failed to achieve” (p. 91). Bsumek (2009) in turn examined the ways in which debate has been framed as a disease by the dialogue and deliberation movement. Bsumek concluded by calling for an activist scholarly agenda to fight-off the trope of debate as disease and reframe it as debate as a “principled facilitated process” (p. 21) in which we can engage in public debate and build community. We see the connection to debate and discussion as much more complex. This current project seeks to document the ways in which debate historically fostered civic democratic ideals by examining the history of the Texas Normal Debate League.

Then and now, differences in student populations have been overlooked. Histories have not examined diverse debate populations very clearly. Keith’s (2007) history, while important in understanding debate and the discussion movement, is itself limited by attention to the dominant form of the university in

the early 1900s: the Liberal Arts College. The claim that “the college environment for debating was elitist but only implicitly, . . . since schools only admitted certain types of people, for the most part, only the elite were involved in debate,” covers over the variety of institutions involved in debate practices at the time (Keith, 2010, p. 14). Attending to the uniqueness of different debate students would provide insight into dealing with the current impasse between competitive policy debate and public deliberation. Communication, and the speech discipline before it, has always had trouble reducing different types of students to fit the mold of good debate standards. Normalizing different backgrounds into a single standard of what constitutes good speaking is at the core of the formation of a single discipline. Indeed the uniqueness of this challenge to produce good speakers from the masses is part of the impetus for the split in 1914 that formed the National Association of Academic Teachers of Public Speaking (Cohen, 1994).

In 1914, the state of speech education was quite different than contemporary understandings of debate pedagogy. The split from English was envisioned to serve a variety of disciplinary goals, even if they were as yet only partially understood. Equally important, this split was designed to serve a variety of different students. One of those original “17 who dared” was an educator at a Normal College: J.S. Gaylord of Winona Normal (Cohen 1994, p. 33). Normal colleges, those with the distinction of training primary school teachers, were a large part of early education (Ogren 2005, Gold, 2008). Indeed, normal colleges were themselves an educational movement in the pre-civil war era United States. Importing a model of teacher education from the French *Ecole Normale*, and following tenets from Swiss universities, these colleges sought to improve standards

for teaching elementary education in the United States (Gold, 2008). Many universities in which speech education played a primary role in the evolution of the discipline of communication began as normal colleges.

The specificity of the normal school education, and the unique mission of these universities has been obscured in the history of speech and debate education. As early as 1922, Rousseau (1922) noted in the *Quarterly Journal of Speech* that “A glance through the indexes of those journals devoted partially or entirely to the interests of speech education shows a most unfortunate lack of information on normal school problems” (p. 209). Unfortunately, this lack of information has yet to be rectified. Even the histories of speech communication as a discipline fail to examine the challenges, burdens, and even missions of the normal schools in educating a group of teachers in speech (e.g., Cohen, 1994; Gehrke, 2009; Keith, 2007). While as a discipline we have sought to plumb the depths of the development of theories, methods, organizations, even departments, relatively little attention has been paid to the pedagogies used to teach the teachers of speech in primary education. To attempt to remedy this lack of historical knowledge, and to begin to trace an argument about the importance of not just the speech educator, but also the speech student in the evolution of the discipline, we examine one local history of normal colleges engaged in furthering speech pedagogy: The Texas Normal Debating League. While many debate leagues function primarily as a pedagogical strategy, we suggest the Texas Normal League functioned in teachers’ colleges as a pedagogical tool as well as a cultural foundation for the process of forming well-rounded citizens in Texas. We use archival documentation in yearbooks, newspapers, and literary journals from Texas colleges and universities, to analyze

the history of “normal” debate in Texas (1906-1923). For modern debate practitioners, the Normal League marks not only debate’s diverse past, but also makes a compelling case that the goals of civic discourse need not be at odds with diverse populations of students. In order to make our argument, we examine first the uniqueness of the normal student, then the history of the Texas Normal Debating league itself, and finally examine the function the league served with regard to this unique student population.

Normalites

While most of the histories of speech as a discipline examine educational practices at Cornell, Iowa, or other large state public institutions, these stories can only present part of the picture. In concert with the tendency to focus on elite institutions, the speech history of normal schools has been treated as “an impoverished past thankfully left behind” (Goodlad, 1990, p. 73). While speech educators no doubt felt the challenges of distinguishing themselves from English teachers (Keith, 2008), the influx of post-war veterans (Gehrke, 2009), or even the birth of journalism as subject of study (Eadie, 2011), normal schools dealt with an entirely new population of college-bound students. Ogren (2003) examined the socio-historical background of students in normal colleges from the late nineteenth and early 20th century and noted that they most closely resemble what we would today call the “nontraditional student.” Unfortunately, nontraditional as a moniker makes it appear that this type of student has not been a member of institutions of higher learning for long, however, close attention to normal schools suggest they were always present in colleges.

Utilizing the term “Normalite,” Ogren (2003) noted that students at normal schools were more likely to be

women, minorities, the first generation of their family to attend any college, working part or full time because of financial necessity, and/or mature in age compared to other college populations. Crucially, they were less prepared for higher education before attending college. Normal schools welcomed students from Puerto Rico and South America. Cecil Evans President of Southwest Texas State Normal School quipped in 1911 that, “Very few Mexican students ever get high enough in the grades to reach us,” implying that at least some Mexicans did reach the Normal school in San Marcos (Quoted in Ogren, 2003, p. 3). In a Progressive Era version of a dual credit system, enrollment in a Normal School did not require a high school diploma and the curricula offered both high school and college subjects to its students (Bohan & Null, 2007).

Bohan and Null (2007) conducted a historical analysis of the Texas normal schools’ curriculum and student and faculty voices vis-à-vis school newspapers, yearbooks, oral histories, and letters. Bohan and Null concluded that gender played an important role in the curricular design and student culture created at Texas normal schools between the late 1890s and early 1920s. During this time period women accounted for two-thirds to three-fourths of the students at normal colleges. For example, 75% (460 of 613) of the students enrolled at North Texas State Normal School in the 1910-1911 academic year were women (Bohan & Null, 2007, p. 15). The large female student population was a sharp contrast to the national average of 40% female students in all colleges in 1910 (Newcomer, 1959, p. 46).

The Normal school became charged with taking students unprepared for higher education and turning them into public school teachers. Thus, their mission was always attached to the goals of democratizing a

citizenry. Normalites, after all, would teach in public schools without boarding-school funding, dealing with the influx of youth from immigrant communities just arriving in the United States in the late nineteenth century, and providing the necessary speech education. As Bohan and Null (2007) noted, normal schools were often free or inexpensive and some degree of public service was expected following teacher certification. For example, students at North Texas Normal College attended for free in the 1910s and in exchange pledged to teach in the public school system for the same length of time as their studies at the college. The normal schools then, even more than the elite institutions, translated academic principles into applied pedagogy: “it was the normal schools . . . that really brought higher education to the people” (Herbst, 1989, p. 142).

In a rare article on the function of the Normal School student in society, Pray (1923) made the argument in the *Quarterly Journal of Speech*:

It is the function of the Normal School to train its students so that they will be competent to handle the speech problems of our schools in a systematic way. Because of the large percentage of foreign pupils in the schools of our large cities it is essential that the teachers have not only a knowledge of English sounds, but also of the foreign sounds that are often substituted for them even in the speech of some of our teachers. (p. 165)

Pray’s comment, arguing for the addition of phonetics training, points out that not only were the Normalites charged with teaching the phonetics of English, but that they themselves may have been speaking in a foreign tongue.

Ogren (2003) noted that this function of the Normal school was most often accomplished outside

of the classroom: “Literary societies enabled students to further pursue some of the topics covered in the curriculum . . . Literary societies also focused on refining their members’ styles of expression and composition. Students wrote and delivered orations and essays on different subjects from week to week” (p. 9). Indeed, the normal education system as a whole emphasized a holistic approach to pedagogy in which extracurricular activities were as important if not more important than classroom studies (Gold 2008). It is from these literary societies that debate clubs formed and out of which the debating leagues prospered.

Texas Normal Debating

In 1879, Texas’ Sam Houston Normal Institute opened in Huntsville. While Texas started later than Vermont and Massachusetts’s normal schools (founded in 1823 and 1839 respectively), Sam Houston was the first such school in the southwestern United States. In 1889, East Texas Normal College was founded in Commerce. In 1891, the North Texas Normal School opened its doors in Denton. In 1903, Southwest Texas State Normal School accepted students into the classroom in San Marcos. In 1910, the West Texas State Normal College was founded in Canyon, Texas. The establishment of these five Normals is a testament to the Progressive Era reforms taking place and an emphasis on education in the United States at the turn of the century (Gold, 2008). While Ivy League schools and large state schools were having their first intercollegiate debates, these schools were just welcoming students. However, almost as soon as their doors opened, normal schools began having their students debate. At first, literary societies formed on campuses and Normalites debated each other in “inter-society debates.” Debating societies seem to have been the earliest activities in most colleges and universities

(Secord & Thomas, 1946, p. 5).

The North Texas Normal School’s (now the University of North Texas) archives provide a detailed timeline: The Kendall-Bruce literary society was founded in 1901 (named for the school’s president and a well-loved professor). The K-B’s, as they were called, were joined by the Reagan literary society in 1902 (named after John Reagan, Texas Senator). After President Kendall passed away the new president requested the name of the group be changed to the Robert E. Lee society in 1906. These groups served the campus with two debates per academic year. A typical inter-society debate involved several events and was often reserved for December or April because being the times before large breaks in the school calendar and giving the debaters ample time to prepare.

The *North Texas State Normal Journal*, “A Monthly Magazine Published under the Auspices of the Literary Societies of the North Texas State Normal College” published the following program for a debate held on campus:

The Lee’s and Reagans are to hold a joint open program Saturday evening, December 3. The following program has been decided upon:

Music Instrumental

Address..... F. A. Ashmore

Debate: Resolved that a department of Education should be added as one of the branches of the President’s cabinet. (Pres. U.S.A.)

Affirmative:—J. D. Hall, W. D. Starcher.

Negative—B. C. Dyess, A. J. Jolley

Music.

Decision of Judges (Palmer, 1910, p. 37)

These campus events involved the students in discussion of ideas and sometimes doubled as commencement celebrations for the students. Such society events were regularly included in monthly notes published in the *North Texas State Normal Journal* and comments were made on how splendid these events were to awaken the mind and entertain. While society debates served an important function, they were limited and normal schools were already aware of other normal school's sports teams, literary journals, music performances, and other student events. Competitive debate would soon follow. At first there were only local college exchanges. For example, North Texas Normal debated Decatur Bible College only 27 miles away in 1906.

In 1907, the San Marcos students challenged the Reagans and Lees to a debate on the North Texas campus. Texas Normal School debating had begun. The North Texas Normal and Southwest Texas Normal had two competitions per year, one school traveling to the other in one semester, the pair flipping in the alternate semester. By 1912 the biannual competitions had enough publicity that the West Texas Normal College in Canyon petitioned to join.

In a meeting in Fort Worth in 1912, representatives from the three colleges' literary societies formed a student-run Tri-Normal Debate League, promising exchanges between the three schools on a regular basis. Each school would debate against the other two in a year, all debating the same topic, the home team always affirming. The Tri-Normal league became the Texas Normal Debating league as Sam Houston Normal Institute and East Texas Normal College joined (in 1914 and 1915 respectively). For a period of more

than ten years, beginning before the formation of the National Academic Association of Teachers of Public Speaking and lasting until the first name change of that organization, Texas' Normal schools, North, West, East, and Southwest, all debated one another regularly, on the same topic, and with an established set of rules governing the competitions. All of these debates had day-long events often including an intercollegiate baseball game held in honor of the debate, dinner celebrations, tours, and other entertainment.

The competitions became grand affairs as one historian noted, discussing the day of a debate in Denton in 1909:

The San Marcos school brought along twenty-three men students for the festivities. The Oratorical Association was host to a reception, with music by the band. During the evening program the Trio Club, Orpheus Octette, and Octette of Strings provided music. The day was "a round of dinners, carriage drives, receptions, banquets, etc." The rivalry blossomed rapidly, outdoing anything that athletic competition yet had to offer. (Rogers, 1965, p. 121)

While the coaches at several of the Normal Schools were women and women were part of the delegation traveling, there is no record of them participating in the intercollegiate debates until 1925 (North Texas State Teacher's College, 1925). It seems the speaking was reserved for the "boys" even though many Normalites were female and the coaches, who were teachers of future primary school teachers, were often women.

In 1917, Durant Normal School in Southeastern Oklahoma petitioned to join and was met by North Texas Normal. By 1919 there is official mention in the annuals of "girls [sic] debating societies." North Texas's

Lillie Bruce Dramatic Society is said to have been formed in 1918 (North Texas State Normal College, 1918) and in 1919 had 40 female members (Davis, 1940, p. 46).

As time passed, the State of Texas approved these schools moving from strictly normal schools, charged with teacher training exclusively and having a mixed population of high school and college students, to be renamed to “Teachers Colleges” with required certifications and standards as well. Southwest Texas Normal School was renamed Southwest Texas Normal College in 1918. North Texas Normal changed to North Texas Teachers College in 1921. Southwest Texas Normal College, West Texas Normal College, Sam Houston Normal Institute, and East Texas State Normal College all dropped the normal and became “teacher colleges” in 1923. These name changes along with the founding of Stephen F. Austin State Teachers College (which was never named a normal) ended the era of normal schools in Texas. With this change, the hybrid high school/college curricula ended and tuition slowly became an item that excluded students of different backgrounds. All of these schools still exist today as Sam Houston State University, Texas A & M Commerce, The University of North Texas, Texas State University, and West Texas A & M University, however, “the slow escalation in tuition over the 20th century also has made these institutions more elitist than they had been in their formative years” (Bohan & Null, 2007, p. 22).

Competitions between normal schools continued when they were called teacher colleges, but the schools themselves had different students, different standards for students, and their mission was changing which reflected their debate matchups. In 1922, North Texas State Teachers College had debate matches against West Texas Normal, Durant Normal, and East Texas

Normal. By 1925, just a few years later, North Texas Teachers College debated San Marcos, Sam Houston, and Durant, but also added Austin College (twice), Simmons College, Abilene Christian College, and a women’s debate against East Texas Teachers College. Which meant 8 total debates in March and April of 1925 compared to three total intercollegiate debates in 1921-1922 (North Texas State Teacher’s College, 1925). By 1927, North Texas Teachers College debated Texas Christian, Baylor, McMurray State, Austin College, Decatur Baptist College, the University of Arkansas, Central Teachers College in Edmund, Oklahoma, Durant Teachers College, Sam Houston, and Southwest Texas Teachers College. North Texas’s women engaged in 7 different debates against Texas Christian, Baylor, Austin College (twice), Trinity (twice), and East Texas (North Texas State Teacher’s College, 1926, 1927). Meaning that only one of seven women’s debates was against a former normal school and only 2 of 12 men’s debates were against a former Texas normal. Students discussed an amazing five different debate resolutions in 1927. All of this meant that while debate competitions were still local, the former normal schools were debating religious institutions and large public universities not focused on molding teachers. Further, the intercollegiate competitions had evolved to include women as participants, not merely just coaches or spectators. In 1928, North Texas State Teachers College (1928) joined Pi Kappa Delta, following Southwest Texas State Teachers College and debate competition became much more national in character (e.g., Ripon Falls, Wisconsin debaters even visited Denton, Texas in 1928).

Normal Debate and Civic Engagement

The context in which the Texas Normal Debate League functions is particularly important. Scholars

rhave established that normal schools were focused on teacher education of primary and secondary school teachers (Bohan & Null, 2007; Gold, 2008; Ogren, 2003; Pray, 1923). During this historical period (1906-1923), the emergence for progressive education and a shift to an experiential approach to training teachers (e.g., practice schools for teacher training as noted in Bohan & Null, 2007) appears to have influenced the degree to which normal debaters approached debate from a civic engagement perspective.

Consider the *North Texas State Normal College Journal*, which in April 1916 opened its issue with an examination of Dewey's *Moral Principles in Education*. The editorial staff of the *Journal* (themselves members of the literary societies), discussed Dewey's comment that "acquiring information can never develop the power of judgment," not only agreeing but also applying that principle to the process by which one becomes a "genuine leader" (p. 17). In order to be an efficient leader, the *Journal* argued, one must:

Size up a situation . . . be able to grasp the scene before him, ignoring what for the time is unimportant, and seize upon factors which demand attention, and grade them according to their respective claims . . . until we have learned to distinguish between sham and sincerity, to distinguish between inferiority and superiority, we shall not be safe leaders. (1916, pp. 17-18)

Esposued for the whole of the Normal College, these skills included; the evaluation of claims, sorting of evidence, and prioritizing what demands attention and what does not. The same skills are prized in competitive debate. In that April issue, the *Journal* devoted five full pages (out of 30 pages) to describing the details of the Durant, San Marcos, and Denton intercollegiate

debates. While short on the details of the arguments in the debates, the topic was emphasized (Resolved: That Foreign Immigration to the United States should be further restricted by the imposition of a literacy test) and the names of the debaters, from all normal colleges, were included. Recently, a number of scholars have maintained that educational practices in normal schools were not only progressive, but also would have employed techniques that would today be considered best practices (Gold 2008, Ogren 2005, Bohan and Null 2007). The normal colleges were engaged, along with Dewey, in the process of transforming education and the debate leagues themselves reflected this in their topics, celebrations, and results.

The formula for these April 1916 stories on the intercollegiate debate followed a pattern replicated in each April issue of the *Journal*, in each newspaper story of the intercollegiate debates in *The Normal Star* (the Southwest Texas Normal school newspaper), and stories about intercollegiate debates included in the annuals of the normal schools. Each article relayed the topic, named the debaters, recounted the events of the trip, revealed the judges' decision, and discussed the reception of the decision. In the next section, we discuss the 1916 exchange as reflective of the goals of the normal league and as evidence of the impact the league made on the debaters, the participants, the observers, and Normalites as a whole.

Discussing Democracy

The purpose of debate leagues was to enhance what students learned in the classroom with a practical approach through competition, a transition from theoretical knowledge to concrete application as well as to form well-rounded citizens. In the Texas Normal League, the topics themselves give insight into

the ways that a well-trained citizen was expected to think. Topics chosen for the Texas Normal League all displayed a timely emphasis and a large scope. Students participating in these debates took on challenging topics, which engaged them in the difficulties of their time. As Dewey (1916) noted, grappling with difficult topics relevant to the democratic process is an important part of his experiential philosophy of education. The students' integration of controversial current events is particularly relevant to such an experiential approach.

In 1916, the Normal Colleges debated a literacy test for immigration (above). While immigration is always a timely and controversial topic in Texas, literacy tests for immigration were an especially difficult subject for the American public in the early 1900s. In the 1890s the Republican Party began calls for a literacy test to stem the wave of immigration. The immigrants causing ire in *that* turn of the century were Southern and Eastern Europeans, Italian and Russian immigrants, and Asian immigrants. In 1906, President Teddy Roosevelt established the "Dillingham Commission" to study the effects of immigration after an attempt to pass a literacy test failed on the floor of the Senate. The Commission recommended a literacy test and it was supported by the American Federation of Labor. However, the literacy test requirement was so contentious that the issue was a perennial House and Senate battle. President Cleveland vetoed a literacy test for immigration in 1897 and again in 1913, after two different bills passed the legislature. President Wilson did the same in 1915. However, in March of 1916, the issue resurfaced and despite the fact that both Republican and Democratic Presidents vetoed a literacy test for immigration a fourth attempt was made. After a fourth Presidential veto, the Senate reached a two-thirds majority and overrode Wilson

establishing the 1917 Immigration Act as law in May 1917. While past immigration laws had imposed a tax or restricted immigration from particular countries (such as the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882 or the "Gentlemen's Agreement" with Japan in 1907) the 1917 Immigration Act was the first law in the United States to impose a general restriction on immigration which took the form of a literacy test. The choice to debate this topic in Normal Schools reflected an emphasis on civic engagement in educational practices.

While it is rare to get the details of what happened in the debates, *The Normal Star* (April 14, 1916) published an account:

Porter and Rasco [the Southwest debaters] argued the position entirely from the standpoint as illiterates. They built up a strong theory that this is an age of progress tending toward education and intelligence, and they showed that the illiterate immigrant was incapable of assimilation into our life. (p.1)

Here the normal focus on pedagogy comes through, rather than focus on the memorization of evidence, the newspaper author conveyed the desire for the debaters to innovate and use different tactics against their opponents. Taking the view of the illiterate immigrants was itself highly progressive, a sort of "pedagogy of the oppressed" in the Progressive Era (Freire, 1970). Further, this strategy attempted to promote understanding of social disparities while simultaneously highlighting the need for extending opportunities and access to immigrant populations. This was an apt lesson from aspiring public school teachers attending college on state-funded tuition waivers.

The Normalites also debated suffrage. On April 8th 1911, San Marcos and Denton students debated the

topic: “Resolved: that the right of suffrage should be extended to women on equal terms as men” (North Texas Normal State School, 1911, p. 120). The 1911 debate was eight years before the controversial Texas vote for suffrage and nine years before women’s suffrage became law on a national scale. The topic had a clear impact on campus, stirring discussion among Normalites before and after the debate. Ervie Joe Blair, junior coed, wrote a yearbook poem about the event in which Denton debaters F.M. Cheney and J.D. Hall took up the negative:

With San Marcos our boys will debate
Whether women shall vote in our state;
So there’s no hope at all,
because Cheney and Hall
Are opposed to us – so sad is our fate.

(North Texas State Normal School 1911, p. 196).

Topics, such as suffrage (North Texas State Normal School, 1911, p. 120), income tax laws (North Texas State Normal, 1912, p. 125), tariffs (North Texas State Normal College, 1916, p. 153), immigration (*The Normal Star*, 1916, p. 1), price fixing (North Texas State Normal College, 1918, p. 120), operation of the railroads (North Texas State Normal College, 1918, p. 119), industrial class immigration (North Texas State Normal College, 1920, p. 159), the creation of a Department of Education (North Texas State Normal College, 1920, p. 162), and labor disputes (North Texas State Normal College, 1920, p. 158) all asked Normalites—who may not have been exposed to the idea of a national public sphere before attending a Normal School—to formulate and defend opinions on the subject. These large social events brought these

topics to Denton, San Marcos, Huntsville, Commerce, and Canyon in a way that lyceums in Cooper Union might have for elite institutions.

None of these topics could have been considered neutral, or even boring for the students of the day. Women’s suffrage, was an issue of political survival for the many women in the debating societies. Indeed, the publication of the poem attempting to make light of the suffrage issue in the school annual attests to both the significance of the topic and of the need for humor to calm tempers. The contrast is stark considering that other universities prohibited discussion on topic of suffrage in the early 1900s. Even progressive Vassar banned discussion and reprimanded students for their off-campus participation with the suffrage movement (Bohan & Null, 2007). Labor reform also would have been a very difficult topic at the turn of the century, when unions were mostly illegal and union sympathizers were political pariahs. Normalites, as has been mentioned before, took this concern for discussion of important issues in the public sphere and returned to public schools with it.

Topics pushed ever more into the realm of the controversial, in 1918 in Canyon the schools debated, “Resolved, That the Policy of Price Fixing on the Staples of Consumption, such as Wheat and Coal, now used as a War Measure, should Be Made a Permanent Policy of Our Government,” (North Texas State Normal College, 1918, p. 120), which asked the negative to disagree with a wartime government decision. In 1920, the Normals debated, “Resolved: That all immigration of the industrial classes into the United States should be prohibited for a period of five years” (North Texas State Normal College, 1920, p. 159). Further, the topics evolved to become increasingly international in scope. In 1923, the Normalites debated, “Resolved: That the

free cancellation of the international war debts among the nations allied against Germany in the recent World War would be for the best interest of the world” (North Texas State Normal College, 1923, p. 190). Thus, these leagues formed politically engaged citizens in college who might become participants in contemporary politics after graduation.

Forming Community

The accounts of intercollegiate Texas Normal Debate League found in the archival documents offer a unique emphasis on building an educational community focused on pedagogy. Dewey (1916) argued that the social environment in which learning occurs “forms the mental and emotional disposition of behaviors in individuals by engaging them in activities that arouse and strength certain impulses that have certain purpose and entail certain consequences” (p. 18). Dewey articulated that it was the teachers’ job to foster this social environment in such a way as to stimulate a thought process in students. Rather than simply providing students with a list of facts to memorize, Dewey argued that students should be challenged to experience their learning by a method of thinking. The uniqueness of the normal schools in contrast to the Liberal Arts College, called for the need to develop a supportive communal identity. All the Normals saw themselves as sister schools, hence, the identity of a Normalite was further supported by engaging in students from other Normal Colleges.

As mentioned above, the intercollegiate debates were large affairs with multiple events in a single trip. Again, the 1916 *Journal* is instructive. In the account of the trip to San Marcos, it relayed that after the 14 Dentonites traveled by train the day before the debate, the day of the debate started early with a joint breakfast

and tour of the city, “all managed to stay in their berths till five-fifteen Saturday morning, when we were most cordially received by the San Marcos delegation. A good breakfast and a view of the city afforded amusement until chapel hour” (*North Texas Normal Journal* 1916, p. 26). After joining chapel services, the Normalites were treated to a special program in the auditorium in San Marcos. They were then given a tour by the river which included a boat ride, a visit to a historic home, and a campus tour. The tour ended, “back to the Domestic Science Hall, where a most delicious dinner was served” (*North Texas Normal Journal*, 1916, p. 26). Here the visitors were made to feel at home with decorations in their home school colors, *The Journal* even comments, “we could almost imagine ourselves back in the halls of N.T.S.N.C. with Dr. Bruce’s birthday cake in view” (1916, p. 26). After lunch, the visitors were entertained by a baseball game between Southwest Texas Normal and Coronal Institute (an industrial college in San Marcos). Even while the students were shown the hospitality of sports viewing, special accommodations were made for faculty, “During these hours the Denton faculty members were very pleasantly entertained at the home of Mrs. Evans, where they met all the ladies of the San Marcos faculty circle” (*North Texas Normal Journal*, 1916, p. 26). After the baseball game and faculty enjoying the ladies circle, the entire party went to the Southwest Texas Normal library, “where an excellent lunch had been prepared by one of the classes for all of the visitors and numerous ones of the home school” (*North Texas Normal Journal*, 1916, p. 26). At the library, toasts were made and “a friendly spirit fostered in spite of the conflict which was about to take place” (*North Texas Normal Journal*, 1916, p. 26). Of the debate, which did not start until after 8pm, the *Journal* only had 2 sentences: “1. North Texas Normal lost, but no one need be ashamed, 2. The ‘rooters’ did

an excellent job of keeping spirits up” (*North Texas Normal Journal*, 1916, p. 26).

The events themselves speak more of a communal gathering between sister schools than of a heated battle of wits and words. In different years the caravan would reach over 40 people, students and faculty, traveling for the intercollegiate event. In 1916, eleven social events preceded the debate, making the trip more of a social visit than a competition. While school spirit certainly dominated the debates, it seems that there was quite a lot of comradery formed by the exchange. And why not? All the Normalites had a number of things in common; many had similar pasts, many were disenfranchised, many were without access to education or wealth. Further, they faced a common future—working as public school teachers. The 1916 *Journal* even relayed that, on the return home, the North Texas Normalites were greeted by an Alumnus (Mr. Knox) now principal in San Antonio and given another day of touring after the debate (which, remember, they lost). The details of the locales visited in that tour were also recounted carefully in *The Journal* (1916, p. 27).

In this regard, the exchange served two purposes for Normalites. First, it formed a community of teachers. Perhaps most important were the interactions between the faculty, sparsely described but always present, in the many travel logs. Professors of Normal colleges faced the task of teaching the teachers of Texas. Many of these debate coaches were women including all four of the 1916’s faculty delegation: Miss Pittman, Miss Sweet, Miss Harriss, and Mrs. Bruce (*North Texas Normal Journal*, 1916, p. 26). The intercollegiate debate exchanges were an invaluable opportunity to build community among female teachers, share teaching strategies, or discuss curricula plans. Further, even though the two debaters were men, three of the ten

in the student delegation were female (Rhea Vernon, Edna Phelps, and Flossie Green) (*North Texas Normal Journal*, 1916, p. 26). And, while women would engage in their own intercollegiate debates regularly after 1923, the 1916 exchange itself created an opportunity for interaction with sister Normalites to build alliances across Texas.

Second, these events contained numerous opportunities for Normalites to interact as scholars in the community. Of the twelve total events relayed on debate day in San Marcos 1916, only three were events exclusively for the campus and students of Southwest Texas Normal. The open lunch and dinner, the tours of the city and river, as well as the debate itself all explicitly invited San Marcos community members. Today we would call this aspect of the exchange community engagement.

Community participation related to the pedagogical mission of the Normal Colleges. Allowing the underprivileged Normalites direct interaction with middle class community members was democratizing. It built community and created opportunities for class mobility by teaching the norms of behavior for people who were members of the middle class and were meant to enjoy river tours and the like. This often overlooked pedagogical feature of the Normal education is a direct outgrowth of the literary societies. Ogren (2005) wrote about Normal Colleges in general:

Student activities, especially the very popular literary societies augmented the liberal-arts curriculum with investigations of literature, music, art, history, and current events. As the acquisition of high-status cultural knowledge helped acquaint students with the mores of the middle class, their involvement in the public sphere of the towns in

which normal schools were located and in campus life further socialized them for participation in middle-class society, and fostered a sense of female autonomy. Thus, the informal mission of the state normal schools also incorporated enabling class mobility and flexibility regarding gender roles. (pp. 201-202)

Ogren's argument about the female Normalites sharpens the importance of these field trips as means to teach future teachers class roles and to allow them to engage democratic deliberation. Gold (2008) has noted learning by doing was a primary strategy of normal education. In his examination of William Mayo, founder of East Texas Normal, Ogren (2008) wrote that Mayo did not merely ask for the East Texas students to be as good as other academics, "but sought to respectfully provide his students with the tools to succeed in that culture, even as he tried to change it" (location 1660).

All of this is not to say that the events were not competitive. Certainly school spirit still reigned in these events. *The Normal Star* recounted that earlier in the fall of 1915, preparations for the debate began "with a war whoop," and noted that "the members of the societies from that time were not allowed to forget even temporarily that we were to overwhelm Denton this year and wipe out Huntsville" (1916, p. 1). In its description of the debate, the *Star* wrote, "the climax was reached Saturday night, April 8, when the S.W.T.N. fully satisfied a long standing desire for revenge against Denton" (1916, p.1). Such violent language betrayed the hospitality offered at the events, but on the very same page of the paper, stories related how the Southwest Normal's men were "treated royally" in Huntsville, and that the fourteen from Denton reported that they were "royally entertained" (*The Normal Star* 1916, p.1). Royal is perhaps the best metaphor as there

was certainly rivalry and the building of school spirit to arouse patriotism, but nothing close to disrespect among these highly regarded rivals which entertained each other yearly.

When asked about the dramatic increase in debate in the literary societies, one of the reporters in the *North Texas State Normal Journal* commented, "The main purpose of the society is truly praiseworthy, the development of each member to make of him a loyal citizen" (Klein, 1911, p. 67). The ideal citizen was thought to be formed through debating but also in the well-rounded nature of the programs that the societies put on for the school.

Normal Lessons

While we have taken great pains to point out the similarities between turn of the 20th Century Normalites and turn of the 21st Century non-traditional students, there are indeed some differences between today's debaters and those of the normal colleges. One important difference is the connection to community.

As we have already suggested, these populations and others may have been debating as early as college itself began. Some were debating in different leagues that have been overlooked by history. The Texas Normal Debating Leagues involved women, rural poor, and students who could not afford to take time out for a liberal arts college. Further, the topic choices, suffrage, labor, and immigration, to name a few, are quite comparable to current debate topics, immigration, trade, even voting rights continue to be prominent topics.

Gold (2008) commented that in addition to trying to instill a sense of democracy in their students, "normal schools also paid close attention to the needs of

the communities they ultimately served-the public and public schools” (location 1709). This is perhaps an area where contemporary debaters and debate practitioners should learn from the Normal League. Debate pedagogy is only realizable if the diverse student body is speaking out. The Normal League debates were the largest academic events of the school year for the normal schools of Texas. The presence of the poems and stories from the school annuals attest to the importance the debates had for not only an academic competition, but also in civic discussion at the time. In this regard, the discussion of immigration, suffrage, tariffs, taxes, and other topics at issue in those days reflects a very different pedagogical effort when directed at future primary school teachers. We suggest that one way in which to negotiate the divide cited by many between contemporary competitive debate and democracy (Bsumek 2009, Keith 2010, “Speech and Debate” 2014) is to refocus debate events on the community which they serve. Community engagement, while implicit in the normal schools of Texas, remains an important goal that must be an important part of any debate program’s pedagogical mission.

This project began simply to address a gap in literature regarding debate in the Normal schools. However, as we went through the archives and the existing histories on debate, we found that the Texas Normal debate league presented a unique objective not always present in national debate leagues. Though there was back and forth about the way in which debate produces “well-rounded” citizens, the Texas Normal debate league successfully promoted engaged citizenship while maintaining a unique pedagogical mission; preparing teachers in a student body consisting of mostly women and poor students without high school degrees.

The early histories of debate discussed the movement toward debate at colleges around the nation as a tool to formulate students that better understood the world around them. In the early 1900s, rural students that were able to perform at the college level in reading and writing were sometimes slow to articulate their understanding of the material (Shurter, 1915). The Texas debate leagues were unique because they did not shy away from using debate for democracy *and* as a pedagogical tool. The debate community in Texas has been about school spirit, citizenship, and teaching from the very early days.

Our analysis of the archival materials and historical context of the Texas Normal Debate League highlights the contemporary tension between debate as a pedagogical tool for civic education and the intensive focus on competition that, as Keith (2007) argued, undermines the ability of debate to fulfill its progressive promise. Our historical analysis suggests that debate topics, and community building in the Texas Normal debates fostered civic engagement by interrogating topics crucial to building civic identity and demonstrated commitment to a community of public debates on topics that shaped the public sphere. However, as noted previously, there was intense focus on competition as demonstrated by the descriptions of the debate events and their outcomes. The paradox between debate as civic minded and collaborative community building versus debate as a competition was present in the Texas Normal Debate League.

Pedagogy was an especially important component in the Texas Normal Debate League since the league was comprised of all “Normal” colleges, or teacher colleges. The debate league functioned as a cornerstone to professionalism in the education world. The Texas Normal league promoted networking and political

investigation. Additionally, students in the league developed debate practices and techniques which were good teaching tools to use in their future places of employment. Thus, debate in Texas worked as a pedagogical method at the college level, but also as a pedagogical tool that the teachers could use to teach to their future students. Many of their students, in turn, would go on to participate in collegiate debate themselves. Indeed, all of their students were affected by the nation's democratic progress.

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